

KEY EVENTS

1914–45

■ **1914** In the second month of World War I, a single German U-boat in the North Sea sinks three British cruisers in one hour.

■ **1916** Forty-four battleships – 28 British and 16 German – are present at the Battle of Jutland, but only a few are sunk in what is an indecisive encounter.

■ **1941** The British battleship HMS *Prince of Wales* and the battle cruiser HMS *Repulse*, sailing off Malaya without air cover, are sunk by land-based Japanese bombers and torpedo aircraft.

■ **1944** The US Navy deploys more than 200 ships against the Japanese at the battle of Leyte Gulf (see pp.348–49), off the Philippines, one of the largest naval battles in history.

■ **1945** The German Type XXI U-boat enters frontline service. It is the first submarine able to submerge for long periods, rather than diving occasionally, and can travel at speed underwater.

▼ AN AMPHIBIOUS TRUCK

The American DUKW (or “Duck”) was one of the ingenious vehicles developed for amphibious operations in World War II. It could carry 25 soldiers ashore and up a beach.



POST-WORLD WAR I
Proof of the effectiveness of submarines, and growing evidence for the importance of naval air power, failed to discourage navies from building bigger and better battleships after 1918. In the 1920s, the Royal Navy thought it had found the answer to the U-boat menace with the ASDIC sonar system, which pinpointed vessels underwater – not considering that they could attack by night on the surface, where their low profile made them virtually undetectable.

KEY DEVELOPMENT

BATTLES AT SEA IN THE WORLD WARS

Command of the seas was a vital element in both world wars. The impact of submarines and aircraft created logistical complications, as well as new danger, for surface fleets, which were themselves increasingly devoted to the support of amphibious landings.

Given the fleets of heavily gunned battleships built in the years leading up to the war, the naval battles of World War I did not follow expectations: there was no climactic, pitched battle between the German High Seas Fleet and the British Grand Fleet. On the only occasion when the two met, at Jutland in the summer of 1916, the Germans fled on discovering the full extent of the British fleet deployed against them, and escaped due to a bungled pursuit. In fact, British superiority in numbers was simply too great to be challenged, even though German warships proved to have better range-finding equipment, better protection against shells, and better night-fighting skills.

German surface warships had been expected to pose a serious threat to British merchant shipping, but it was the German U-boats that turned out to be the biggest threat. Having disposed of the majority of Germany's warships early in the conflict, Britain's Royal Navy were frighteningly vulnerable to mines and submarines, leading to caution in all fleet operations. The belated introduction of convoys accompanied by Royal Navy warships, from the summer of 1917, reduced losses, but U-boats remained a constant danger.

World War II brought epic naval conflicts in the Atlantic, Pacific, and Mediterranean, with the British, German, Italian, American, and Japanese navies engaged in fierce combat. This time the major shock for navies was the vulnerability of even the most powerful warships to air attack. Within range of hostile aircraft, surface ships were dangerously exposed without air cover. German magnetic mines caused havoc

“The only thing that ever truly frightened me during the war was the U-boat peril”

BRITISH PRIME MINISTER WINSTON CHURCHILL

